



Chapter 3

MAHĀBHĀRATA - WHATS AND WHATNOTS

Now we know the main story line.

Yet, some may ask, what treasures lie within its narration that warrant our devoted attention? What lessons and insights does this venerable epic offer to us, the modern generation? Why, indeed, should we seek to befriend this ancient one who has stood the trials of time?



MAHĀBHĀRATA - WHATS AND WHAT NOTS

An Itihāsa is an effort to convey the universal truth as stories related to humans and non-humans. Mahābhārata, one of the greatest Itihāsa composed by Veda Vyāsa, aims to express and narrate eternal truths on human nature. It touches upon various aspects like how truth can be experienced, communicated, understood, and verified. Such truths are derived from thousands of years of observation, study, and analysis by Ṛṣis and other dedicated scholars. The Ṛṣis are often called 'Mantra dr̥ṣṭākkal'. 'Dr̥ṣṭākkal' means one who has experienced it. They are not the creators of aphorisms. These truths are verbal expressions of what they have experienced and understood in their meditations. All the aphorisms expressed by the great Ṛṣis based on their experiences have been combined, classified, and edited by the great sage named Kṛṣṇa Dvaipāyana. Since he edited it, he came to be known as the editor of the Vedas or Veda

Vyāsa. Each Veda has been classified into four texts - Saṃhitā, Āraṇyaka, Brāhmaṇa, and Upaniṣads. All four categories consist of three types of statements: Praśasti Vākya, the Vidhi Vākya, and the Jñāna Vākya.

The decorative statements that narrate the fame or infamy of a deity, an incident, a person, or an experience are called Praśasti Vākya. Since it involves the components of fame and infamy, there must be an act of commission and omission based on the likes and dislikes of the concerned person. Committing and omitting will take away the veracity of the narrative. So, all the Saṃhitā statements are Praśasti Vākyas, not the statements of the truth. For example, it is natural for human beings to commit to one thing based on their likes and dislikes. If someone praises something, it does not necessarily mean that they have made a statement based on an authentic evaluation of their experience. It would be out of their personal choices, likes, and dislikes.

Another aspect is the Vidhi Vākyas. Vidhi Vākyas are generally concerned with the dos and don'ts in a person's life. People's discretion to do or not do something depends on their individual contexts. Such deciding factors depend on the situation. For instance, a person might be expected to do something in a particular context but not the same in another context. It is a variable entity. These two types of statements have been compiled in Brāhmaṇās and Āraṇyakās.

The third aspect is the statement of truth. It is like an equation. The syntactic order of the statements can't

change in the structure or the meaning of the statements. For example, $2+2=4$. The statement is still valid if you put it in the reverse order, $4=2+2$. Similarly 'Ahaṃ Brahma asmi', 'Brahma ahaṃ asmi' or 'tatvaṃ asi', 'Asi tatvaṃ'. No matter how you change the order of the words, the meaning of the statement remains unchanged. The Upaniṣads mainly consist of statements of truth. Brahma Sūtra is a text on the Vedānta system. It is derived from Vedas by taking statements of truth and placing them in a systematic order.

Another important aspect of Mahābhārata is the Gītā. Gītā shows how the lessons from ancient texts can be applied in a practical context. The Vedic aphorisms are actualized in the Gītā in accordance with real-life circumstances. So, the Vedas or the Upaniṣads are the sourcebooks, Brahma Sūtra is the text and Bhagavadgītā is the technology with which the lessons are enacted and undertaken.

Mahābhārata is a text that contains the technology of the Vedānta system. That's why Vyāsa called Mahābhārata the fifth Veda.

Why is it called the Fifth Veda?

If one needs to learn Veda, there are two major aspects related to the person learning. One is eligibility and the other is competence. For instance, those who pass a degree course are eligible to become civil servants. But they are not all competent to become civil servants. Similarly, according to the Indian system of thought mentioned in the Vedas, all human and non-human beings are eligible to attain Mokṣa

– the ultimate purpose of every living being. Unlike other religious notions, heaven is not the final destination in Indian thought. It is not a permanent destination. Once your time is over, you may have to come back to earth.

According to Indian systems of thought, every living being is eligible for the attainment of Mokṣa. In the case of human beings, all of them are not competent in learning the Vedas. They can fulfil the eligibility criterion but may not be competent to learn the Vedas. A set of rules must be observed for learning Vedas. Human beings may fail to practice rigorous vratas and training systematically envisaged by the Ṛṣis for this purpose. Here comes the relevance of Vyāsa's fifth Veda- Mahābhārata. It conveys lofty ideas in simple words. Thus, it helps those who are eligible for the attainment of Mokṣa but are incompetent due to their inabilities. And to attain Mokṣa, Mahābhārata offers a distinctive means for them through the multifaceted life experiences illustrated in it. The principal purpose of writing Mahābhārata was to illustrate how Dharma operates and explicates the operation of Dharma in numerous contexts. The brilliant and imaginative narration of the text teaches incalculable lessons eloquently to whoever studies it.

What is the essence of Dharma?

Vyāsa says that the essence of Dharma is Niṣkāma Karma which is the central topic explained in every anecdote of Mahābhārata. Niṣkāma Karma means the performance of Karma without having the touch of the Kārmic elements. A

person's act of serving others by controlling his sense organs and mind is called Niṣkāma Karma. Niṣkāma Karma is widely misunderstood by the presumed intelligentsia as a confined term, discussed and elaborated only in the Bhagavadgītā. Niṣkāma Karma suggests that one has to be selfless while performing Karma. It is found everywhere in the universe.

For instance, the human body is dynamic. Anything dynamic must undertake some action as well as undergo some reactions. So, inaction or inactivity is logically an inconceivable term. The human body must inevitably be engaged in some activities.

While undertaking actions, one must keep in mind that it should be beneficial to everyone. Being a social animal, everything is part of human life - both good and bad. Everyone must commit themselves to Niṣkāma Karma at some point in their lives. One must be responsible for their actions / dormancy and cannot blame any external force for its results. One must have control over their actions, think about its pros and cons, and control their sense organs and manas. This is what Mahābhārata teaches you through the life stories of various characters.